

PDF file name: Oasis-2018-Drug use among youth and adults

Original article word count: 1746

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Title of the article: *Drug use among youth and adults in a population-based survey in South Africa*

The content extracted is as follows:

Method

Cross-sectional data from the 2012 South African national HIV prevalence, incidence, and behaviour survey was analysed.¹³ The sampling strategy was stratified by province, type of geolocality and predominant population or racial groups.

The detailed survey methods are described elsewhere.¹³ Drug use in the past 3 months was assessed with 10 items of the Alcohol, Smoking and Substance Involvement Screening Test (ASSIST), e.g. In the past 3 months, how often have you used cannabis (dagga, marijuana, pot, grass, hash, etc.)?

Any drug use in the past 3 months was coded as 1 and never as 0.

All items were added together to indicate the prevalence of any illicit drug use in the past 3 months.

Psychological distress was measured with the Kessler Psychological Distress Scale (K-10).¹⁵ The 10-item scale assesses global psychological distress experienced in the past 30 days, e.g. In the past 30 days, how often did you feel so restless that you could not sit still?

(coded two or more = 1 and 0 to 1 sexual partner = 0).¹³ Descriptive statistics were used to summarise drug use prevalence, sociodemographic factors and health variables.

Associations between the outcome variable of any past 3-month drug use (cannabis, cocaine, amphetamine, inhalants, sedatives, hallucinogens or opiates including Whoonga), sociodemographic and health risk-independent variables were examined by calculating odds ratios.

Unconditional multivariable logistic regression was utilised to assess the impact of explanatory variables for the outcome of past 3-month drug use prevalence, for women and men separately.

Results

Response rates for the interview was 89.5%.¹³ The total sample included 26 453 persons aged 15 years and older, 52.0% women and 48.0% men.

More than half of the participants (52.0%) were between 15 and 34 years old, 40.2% had Grade 12 or more education, 77.8% were from the African black population group, 39.3% were formally or informally employed and 51.9% lived in urban formal areas.

Overall, the past 3-month of any drug use was 4.4%, 7.9% among men and 1.3% among women.

The proportion of the past 3-month cannabis use was 4.0%, followed by sedatives or sleeping pills (Valium, Mandrax, Serepax, Rohypnol, etc.) 0.4%, amphetamine-type stimulants (speed, ecstasy, tik, etc.) 0.3%, cocaine (coke, rocks, crack, etc.) 0.3%, opiates (heroin, morphine, methadone, codeine, Whoonga [mixture of heroin, cannabis and alleged antiretrovirals], etc.) 0.3%, inhalants (nitrates, glue, petrol, paint, thinners, etc.) 0.2%, and hallucinogens (lysergic acid diethylamide [LSD], acid, mushrooms, Phencyclidine [PCP], Special K, etc.) 0.1%.

The prevalence of past 3-month drug by injection was 0.6%, and the use of Whoonga 0.2%.

Among the nine South African provinces, any past 3-month drug use was the highest in the Western Cape (7.1%), followed by the Free State (6.3%), Northern Cape (5.2%) and Gauteng (4.9%) (see Table 1).

survey in the US (past month 10.1%).⁴ Among the different drugs used, the highest past 3-month prevalence was for cannabis (4.0%), as found in the 2008 South Africa survey (3.3%)⁵ and also in other countries such as the US.⁴ Compared to the 2008 South Africa national survey,⁵ in this 2012 survey the prevalence of past 3-month use increased from 3.3% to 4.0% for cannabis use, while it decreased for sedatives or sleeping pills from 0.8% to 0.4%, amphetamine-type stimulants 0.7% to 0.3%, cocaine 0.6% to 0.3%, opiates 0.5% to 0.3%, hallucinogens from 0.5% to 0.1% and inhalants from 0.5% to 0.2%.⁵ The increase in the prevalence of past 3-month drug use from 2008 to 2012 seems to be even higher among the

youth (15–24 years) from 4.2% to 5.7%.

The increase in the prevalence of cannabis use may be attributed to lower costs and better accessibility than the other drugs.

In a qualitative study: The use of amphetamine-type stimulants including tik and others had been as high as 2.2% in the Western Cape province in the 2008 survey,⁵ but was only 0.8% in the Western Cape in this survey, which may indicate some form of control as compared to previously.²⁰ The increase in the use of drugs by injection from 0.3% in 2008 to 0.6% in 2012 is of concern.

A study of 450 people who inject drugs (PWID) in South Africa found that they engaged in high HIV risk behaviour, including 49.0% having used contaminated injecting equipment the last time they injected.²¹ As found in previous studies,^{5,6,7,22} including in South Africa, the prevalence of drug use was significantly higher among men than women.

Limitations

The data on drug use were collected by self-report and may underreport the true consumption rate.²³ Furthermore, the internal consistency of the ASSIST questionnaire for the drug use section was only moderate (0.61).

Conclusion

An increase of any illicit drug use prevalence rates was observed from 2008 to 2012 in South Africa.